COMPLIANCE & SECURITY · TEMPLATE

Data Handling and Classification Policy Template

For founders and operations leaders who need a clear, adoptable standard for how data is stored, shared, accessed, used with AI, and retired.

> **How to use this:** Define your classification tiers first, then map where sensitive data currently lives, including AI tools, before setting handling rules for each tier.

Classification Tiers

Define what falls into each tier for your business specifically, using real examples, not abstract categories.

Tier	Examples for our business	Who can access	Handling rule	AI tools allowed?
Public			No special handling required	Any approved tool
Internal			Standard access controls, no external sharing	Approved tools on company accounts
Restricted			Encryption, minimal access, no copying into unapproved tools	Only tools approved for this tier, under a signed data processing agreement

Where Sensitive Data Actually Lives

Where is customer personal data (names, emails, addresses) stored?

Where is customer payment or financial data stored, and who has access?

Where are credentials, API keys, and secrets stored?

What data do support and success teams handle that may include sensitive information?

What data do we collect that we no longer have a clear business reason to keep?

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AI Data Stores

AI has created new places for sensitive data to accumulate. Most were never added to the data map.

AI data store	Where it lives	Contains restricted data?	Retention	Owner
Prompts and chat history				
Files uploaded to AI tools				
AI outputs saved to drives or tickets				
Embeddings or vector databases				
Agent memory and logs				
Model provider logs				

Storage and Sharing Rules

- [ ] Restricted data is never stored in general-purpose tools not approved for it (personal drives, chat exports, spreadsheets).
- [ ] Restricted data is never shared externally without an approved, secure method.
- [ ] Access to restricted data is logged or limited to a named, small group.
- [ ] New tools, including AI tools, are checked against this policy before sensitive data is put into them.
- [ ] We know which countries personal information is stored or processed in, including by AI providers, and have checked that overseas handling meets our obligations.
- [ ] Support and sales teams have clear guidance on what customer data can and cannot be pasted into AI tools.

Retention and Retirement

Set a default retention period for each data type and an actual mechanism for deleting it.

Data type	Retention period	Deletion method	Owner
Customer account data (active)			
Customer account data (post-cancellation)			
Support ticket contents			
Financial / payment records			
Logs and analytics data			
AI prompts, outputs and embeddings			

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Adoption and Review

- [ ] The policy has been shared with the whole team, not just engineering or leadership.
- [ ] New hires are walked through data classification during onboarding.
- [ ] The policy is reviewed at least annually, or when a new tool or data type is introduced.
- [ ] A named owner is responsible for keeping this policy current.

Where This Maps

Framework or obligation	Where this resource lines up
Australian Privacy Act	APP 6 use and disclosure; APP 8 cross-border disclosure; APP 11.1 security; APP 11.2 destroy or de-identify information no longer needed
NZ Privacy Act 2020	IPP 5 storage and security; IPP 9 not keeping information longer than necessary; IPP 12 overseas disclosure
UK GDPR	Article 5(1)(c) data minimisation; Article 5(1)(e) storage limitation; Article 32 security
ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Annex A	5.12 classification; 5.13 labelling; 5.34 privacy and protection of PII; 8.10 information deletion
ISO/IEC 42001 Annex A	A.7 data for AI systems

General guidance, not legal advice. References to standards show where this resource aligns; using it does not make an organisation compliant or certified. Check your specific obligations with a qualified adviser. Regulatory references checked October 2026.

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